

The Second Renaissance

A time of civilizational crisis and awakening

“Two young fish are swimming along and they meet an older fish swimming the other way. The older fish nods at them and says ‘Morning, boys. How’s the water?’ The two young fish swim on for a while. Then one of them looks over at the other and goes ‘What the hell is water?’”

— David Foster Wallace

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Introduction

The Second Renaissance is both a period and a movement: a “time between worlds”, and a growing movement of people working to build shared understanding towards a radically wiser future.

FROM THE CLIMATE CRISIS to populism, from rising inequality to AI risk, visible and growing cracks are appearing in planetary civilization. Accurate diagnosis is vital if we are not only to address the symptoms but heal, transform and transcend our interconnected crises. The stakes are high — never before has human civilization risked collapse on a global scale. Here we will suggest that these growing cracks go to the foundations of our societies: to the way we see ourselves, each other and the world. At the very root of the challenges we face is a dying cultural paradigm: Modernity. The modern era was itself a period of extraordinary human achievement and advance, initiated by a cultural Renaissance or rebirth. However like any paradigm, Modernity casts a long shadow, and ultimately contained the seeds of its own decline.

Whatever its gifts, today Modernity is exhausted. We find ourselves unable to address our current crises through the Modern logic and value systems that created them.

We need profound shifts in our ways of being, thinking, feeling and acting: a Second Renaissance. And we need proactive people willing to dedicate themselves to imagining collectively what this might look like. By becoming aware of where we are standing within the long view of history and examining how we got here, we can begin to imagine where we might go next, and how we might avoid repeating the same mistakes.

Here we will introduce a provisional model for understanding cultural evolution at a foundational level, and a set of tools for navigating our cultural landscape — and exploring new territory. We will propose that a wholesome transition must prioritize the human inner world as well as the outer structures of society. And we will suggest that creating pragmatic ways to embody and enact new ideas in our lives together is every bit as important as the ideas themselves.¹

On the word “renaissance”

We have adopted the imperfect term “Second Renaissance” in the understanding that no one term will universally feel appropriate, or do justice to the variety of transformation taking place. In particular, we recognize the eurocentric nature of the term — and encourage readers, if they wish, to substitute a term more relevant to their own cultural context.

At the same time, the term has certain useful resonances. The current dominant cultural paradigm of modernity was born in the first renaissance in Europe, though we emphasize that this next transition will have many roots all over the world. In addition, the basic meaning of the term — rebirth — seems appropriate to this “time between worlds”, and offers a framing of possibility whilst also implicitly acknowledging the risks of breakdown and collapse. Birth and death are profoundly intertwined.

¹This essay refers broadly to “we” and to “our world”, without intending to reduce the plurality of human experience to any single or simple thing. Similarly we discuss globally dominant structures of thought that coalesced at a particular time in Europe, without implying that they are absolute or consented to by all.

Modern Civilization: Cracks in the Walls

If our solutions are failing, it is worth interrogating whether we are misdiagnosing the problems.

FROM POVERTY AND SPIRALING inequality to ecological breakdown, rising authoritarianism and social fragmentation, globalized modern civilisation faces major threats. For the good of all life, we urgently require meaningful solutions. But we have known this for a while, and thus far our interventions are not working very well. Let's start with a metaphor. You've lived in your house for a number of years and everything about it has seemed more or less fine. A few years ago you had to do some damp-proofing, perhaps. And there was that time a bunch of tiles slid off the roof — but nothing serious. Recently however, you've started noticing cracks appearing in some of the walls. You're no slacker, and you already plastered over them, but rather alarmingly they just came back — and they're getting bigger. Now the upstairs doors won't close properly and yesterday a little bit of ceiling-plaster fell into the bath.

Are these co-occurring breakdowns a coincidence? Do you just carry on with the Polyfilla? Or is it time to start asking whether there's a common source problem coming from somewhere deeper — most likely the foundations?

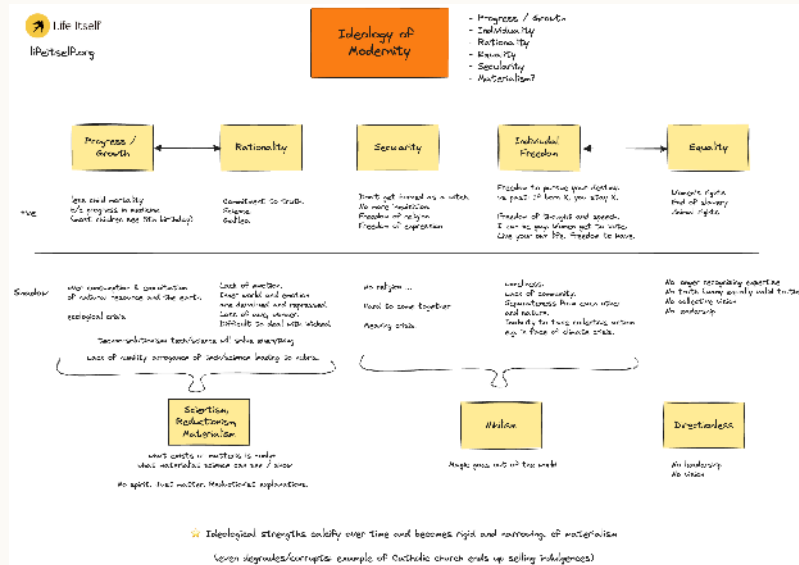


Figure 1. The visible crises are not independent. Read as symptoms of a common foundational problem, they stop looking like a list and start looking like a diagnosis.
Source: *Life Itself*

We don't want our problems to be foundational. Going so deep, with so much complicated stuff layered on top of them, they're hard to access. To fix them properly, large parts of our house might need to be rebuilt entirely. We may even need to pack up and move.

It's tempting to keep plastering over each crack as best we can. But those symptoms will keep showing up, and getting worse.

If our foundations are flawed, our only real option is to deal with the root of the problems — to start in the basement. The alternative is to keep fixing the wrong problems as our house collapses around us: gradually, then perhaps all at once.

What Are the Foundations of Civilization?

Among the most fundamental aspects of a built structure are the core ideas that guided its construction, and that continue to motivate the people who maintain it.

IF WE'RE IN AGREEMENT, then it might be time to examine the foundations of civilization. But where are they, exactly? Like most metaphors, our house is imperfect and radically oversimplified — if human civilization were bricks and mortar we wouldn't be struggling so hard to fix it.

Complex interdependencies entail that no aspect of a system is foundational in any simple sense. However we might argue that among the most fundamental aspects of a built structure are the core ideas that guided its construction. Terminology varies — but whether we talk about worldviews, cultural paradigms, belief systems, or similar, we're essentially pointing to the deep structures of views and values that underpin individual choices and societal norms.

Views core frameworks of assumptions about the nature of reality: what the world is, how it works, and humanity's place within it.

Values core beliefs about what matters: what is good, meaningful and desirable.

Views and values are mutually implicit, and always operating within human choice and behaviour at individual and societal levels.

Why they are hard to shift

A number of characteristics suggest views and values as foundational in civilization. Importantly, these structures of thought tend to be more resistant to change than technological and institutional structures. Over time a feedback mechanism emerges: we co-create structures and institutions that formalise certain views, and in channelling societal life through those structures we entrench the values they embody.

The intransigence of views and values arises in part from their close relationship with personal and group identity. Because core beliefs about what's right or real are typically experienced as indistinguishable from “who I am”, challenges to views can be received as a personal or cultural attack — attracting strong resistance and redoubled attachment to existing beliefs.

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— David Foster Wallace, after a Chinese proverb

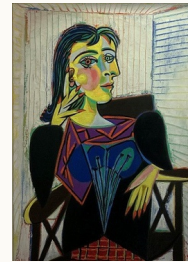
Like the fish, unaware of the water it's swimming in, we perceive reality without awareness of the mental models that deliver it to our perception — and particular views and values are often most visible to those living outside them in some way. As well as speaking to their foundational nature, this invisibility reinforces the difficulty we may have in shifting views and values, and our related tendency to neglect their importance when diagnosing societal challenges.



Cimabue, before linear perspective: space is symbolic, not measured.



Perugino: one vanishing point, one correct place to stand.



Picasso: several viewpoints held at once, none privileged.

Figure 2. Three ways of rendering space, six centuries apart. The paradigm is not what is depicted but what counts as depicting correctly — which is exactly the kind of assumption that is invisible from inside it.